Singh's own execution now provided the nationalists' cause with a martyr at a time when few prominent figures gave their lives. It is the symbolic value of such martyrdom that has through time proved to be of inestimable value.

Gandhi was derided for failing to save these young men whom he described as 'deluded patriots'. He had meetings with Lord Irwin but did not insist on clemency. Deluded or not, the fact remains that Bhagat Singh forged a new ideological pathway as never before. Indian revolutionaries had hitherto only rejected the twin evils of capitalism and colonialism. Bhagat Singh wanted to do more. He rejected religion because it alienated the masses. But the rejection of religion for Bhagat Singh also had instrumentalist objectives. It served his socialist agenda of denouncing another towering edifice of oppression, namely, casteism. In this way, Bhagat Singh linked capitalism with casteism. He was the first revolutionary to do so. Yet, he was only twenty-three years old at the time of his execution. From the time he left National College in Lahore, the period of his activism was just seven years, from 1924 to 1931.

Today Bhagat Singh has achieved the unique distinction of being the only person who unites India and Pakistan in his vision of what they stand for as independent nations. His death anniversary on 23 March is celebrated as 'Bhagat Singh Day' in Pakistan every year. There are poems and songs recited in his name on the very spot where he was hanged. When there are causes to fight for, student demonstrations and protests carry banners dedicated to him.

Pakistan has long been in search of suitable icons. For a long time, one such was thought to be Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, the man accredited with democratizing and empowering Pakistan's poor in the 1970s. Bhutto was progressive, socialist and liberal. However, he made the cardinal error of appeasing his right-wing religious opponents by defining a Muslim in Pakistan's 1973 Constitution making Ahmedis outcasts. Bhagat Singh avoided such pitfalls, which is why some three-quarters of a century after his hanging, the high court in Pakistan was presented with a petition on 3 February 2016 to set aside the verdict of death on Bhagat Singh. That petition is still pending.